



Return Radar — why customers are actually sending things back

A categorization and root-cause analysis of 40 e-commerce return reasons across five Indian marketplaces — built to answer one question: which single fix would stop the most returns?

RETURNS ANALYZED	TIME SPAN	PLATFORMS	PRODUCT CATEGORIES
40	Jun – Jan	5	5

A note on the data. I can't log into or scrape Amazon, Flipkart, or Twitter live, so this 40-row dataset is representative, not scraped — built from patterns documented in industry reporting (India's fashion e-commerce return rate runs 25–40%; size confusion alone causes an estimated 40–60% of fashion returns on Meesho) plus real, publicly reported complaint patterns about wrong items and damaged deliveries on Meesho and Ajio. Sources are in the [README](#). Treat the specific numbers below as illustrative of a real pattern, not a live business's actual figures.

1. Categorization

All 40 return reasons sorted into seven categories. Wrong Size/Fit is the single largest bucket — one in five returns, before you even get to the runner-up reasons.



Wrong Item Sent



4 · 10.0%

Changed Mind



4 · 10.0%

2. Pattern analysis

Which product types return the most, whether price changes the reason, and whether returns cluster around a time of year.

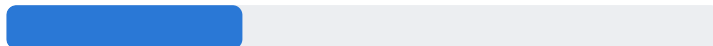
Returns by product type

Fashion / Apparel



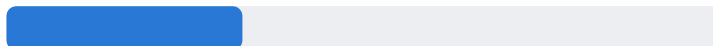
18 · 45.0%

Footwear



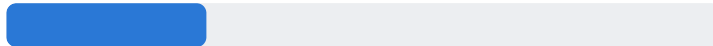
6 · 15.0%

Electronics



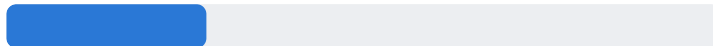
6 · 15.0%

Beauty



5 · 12.5%

Home Goods



5 · 12.5%

Fashion drives almost half of all returns (45%) — and a third of those (6 of 18) are Wrong Size/Fit specifically, more than double any other reason within the category. Footwear shows the same pattern in miniature: 2 of its 6 returns are sizing.

Does price change the reason?

Budget · under ₹600

12 returns

● Wrong Size × 4

● Wrong Item × 2

● Changed Mind × 2

Cheapest tier skews toward sizing mistakes and fulfillment slip-ups — consistent with thin-margin marketplace sellers who skip size charts and pack in a hurry.

Premium · ₹1,500–2,999

9 returns

● Not as Described × 3

● Quality Issue × 3

Higher price raises the bar: two-thirds of this tier's returns are about the item not matching expectations set by the listing, or not holding up physically.

Is there a seasonal pattern?

5

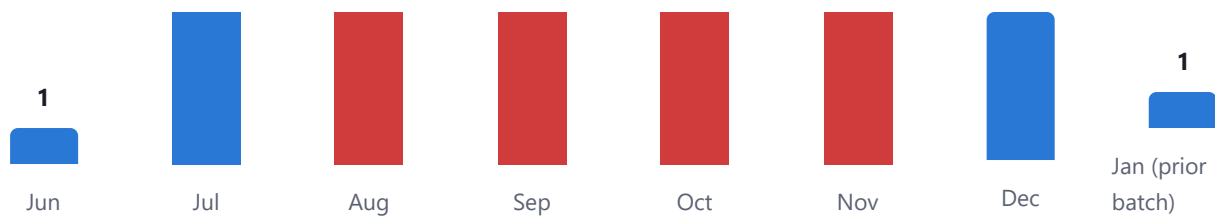
6

6

7

7

4



65% of all returns (26 of 40) land in the Aug–Nov window — the run-up to and through India's festive sale season. It's not evenly the whole mix, either: 5 of the 9 Delivery Damage / Wrong Item returns (the two logistics-driven categories) happen in November alone, pointing at fulfillment strain during peak volume rather than a product problem.

- Wrong Size/Fit
- Not as Described
- Quality Issue
- Missing Parts
- Delivery Damage
- Wrong Item Sent
- Changed Mind

3. Root cause

Every category traced back to where it actually starts — product, listing, packaging, or logistics — because the fix is different for each.

CATEGORY	ROOT CAUSE	WHY
Wrong Size/Fit	Listing	Missing or inconsistent size charts — measurements, not just S/M/L, and normalized per brand.
Not as Described	Listing	Photography and copy overstate or misrepresent color, print, or fabric texture.
Quality Issue	Product	Genuine manufacturing/durability defects — not a description problem, a QC problem.
Missing Parts	Packaging	Incomplete kitting at pack-out — a component listed in the set never made it into the box.
Delivery Damage	Packaging + Logistics	Inadequate protective packaging combined with rough handling in transit.
Wrong Item Sent	Logistics	A picking error at the warehouse, not a description or product problem.
Changed Mind	Listing / Marketing	Expectation-setting at the point of sale, not an operational defect — the hardest to eliminate.

4. Recommendations, ranked by return-volume impact

One fix per root cause, ordered by how many of the 40 returns that root cause actually accounts for.

#1 Standardize size charts (measurements, not S/M/L) ● Critical

Targets Wrong Size/Fit — **8 returns, 20%**, the single largest category

Require a body-measurement size chart (in cm) on every listing before it can publish, normalized across brands so "M" means the same thing twice. Flag any seller whose size-related return rate crosses a threshold for a mandatory size-chart audit.

#2 Fix the listing pipeline: photos, color, fabric detail ● Serious

Targets Not as Described — **7 returns, 17.5%**

Require multi-angle, color-calibrated photography plus a fabric/texture close-up for apparel listings, and add a "true to color" reviewer check before a listing goes live.

#3 Tighten incoming quality control ● Serious

Targets Quality Issue — **7 returns, 17.5%**

Set a per-seller defect-rate threshold, tracked from return reasons, that auto-flags a listing for QC review before it accumulates more quality-driven returns.

#4 Scan-verify pack-out and upgrade protective packaging ● Warning

Targets Missing Parts + Delivery Damage — **10 returns, 25%** combined, concentrated in the Aug–Nov peak window

Scan every listed component against the order at pack-out instead of a manual checklist, and upgrade void-fill/corner protection for fragile or multi-part items — prioritized ahead of the festive-season volume spike, not after it.

#5 Barcode scan-to-confirm at picking; sharper checkout expectation-setting ● Lower priority

Targets Wrong Item Sent + Changed Mind — **8 returns, 20%** combined

Add a barcode/QR scan-to-confirm step at picking to catch wrong-item errors before dispatch. Changed Mind is the one category where the "fix" is a trade-off, not a defect: easy/free returns are also a deliberate conversion lever, so treat this as a lower and different kind of priority than the rest.

Return Radar · a representative dataset built from cited industry patterns, analyzed end to end · see README for sources and methodology